

Figure 4: Working with pasted layers

- **Arrows:** Arrows let you change the position of a layer. You can move a layer above or below with the help of these arrows. However, since the GIMP provides you with the easy dragging and dropping of layers, these arrows are actually a farce.
- **Duplicate layer:** As the name suggests, this tool lets you duplicate the current selected layer with a simple click. One very handy tool for making bold effects.
- **Anchor layer:** This tool only comes into action when you paste an image or a layer to the current active image window. This lets you merge the pasted layer with the background layer.
- **Delete layer:** This lets you delete an unwanted layer.

At the middle, you must have noticed some additional tools/sections (Figure 3). These form an integral part of the Layer List section, letting you perform various effects.

- **Layer preview:** On creating a layer, you will either

notice a white/transparent or coloured section, depending on the type of layer you have created. Once you start creating an image, this small section provides a preview of the effects created in the main editing window. Though not of great use, it helps you distinguish between layers when working with images boasting of a huge number of layers.

- **Layer eye—Enable/Disable layer:** The eye that you see in Figure 3 lets you toggle the visibility of a layer.
- **Layer link:** This tool locks the layer. It combines the layer and lets you move multiple layers simultaneously, providing precise control while moving layers. The layer link comes in very handy at times and helps you restore the effect to its original state, even after moving the linked layers.
- **Layer mask:** To the right side of the layer preview, there is a Layer Mask option, as shown in Figure 3. The Layer Mask is an add-on that you can use as you wish. It controls the visibility of the layer. Initially the Mask is disabled, you can add it if you want. If a white mask (opaque) is selected, the layer in which the mask is applied will become visible, while a black mask (transparent) will make the layer transparent; even if there is image editing done on that main layer, it will not be visible, as the dark mask hides the drawn parts. Selecting the layer mask by clicking on it makes it active and after creating the mask, all the drawing done appends to the mask, and not to the layer.

Managing layers

Pasting/dropping layers is an essential part of editing images. Whenever you paste an image in the GIMP, it goes into floating transition. What this means is that the image pasted is not permanent yet. You can make

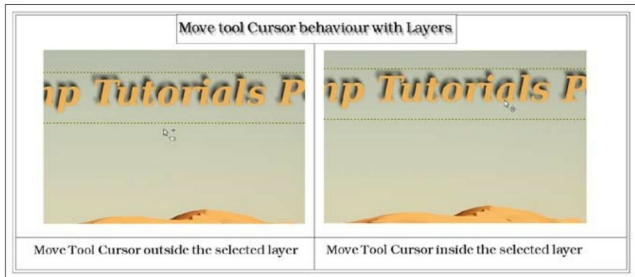


Figure 5: Cursor behaviour with layers